It is almost cruel to criticize this wretched piece of writing. Every thought was wrong, every paragraph contained multiple errors, and each word somehow made the one before it worse.[323] Even the subheading—"A Nation of Exaggerators"—remains offensive to this day.

As it turned out, the United States was already in month nine of the worst recession since the Great Depression. The Sunday when *The Washington Post* edition with this column landed on doorsteps throughout Washington D.C., things were about to get a whole lot worse. That very day, Lehman Brothers blew up; it filed for bankruptcy the very next day (September 15, 2008); insurance giant American International Group also blew up that day, but AIG, unlike LEH, was deemed "systemically important" and was bailed out.

You need to read the entire column to get a full measure of how awful it was. It denied the housing slump, misread the debt markets, stated that bank capital was more than sufficient, looked at employment trends as proof there was no recession, applauded economic growth levels, decried the use of the terms "crisis" and "meltdown"—and gets every single one of these issues exactly wrong. If you had a time machine, knew the future, and purposefully tried to write something as wrong as possible, you could not have done a better job.

Had you listened to his advice—things aren't that bad, just relax—and bought equities, you were about to suffer a 46% collapse. A year after the column came out, markets were still off by almost 20%.

Hey, anyone can have unlucky timing for any one column. But what makes Luskin stand out among all of the other terrible market commentators is his consistency. Readers who followed his columns regularly lost money with his terrible, mistimed advice.

Almost a year prior to the "Quit Doling" column, Luskin told us there were "11 Reasons to Buy Stocks Now."[324] That was November 2007, a month after the market peak and the start of a nauseating 18-month, 57% slide in